He stated that Palkhivala had spearheaded the decision to deny the enterprise funds as a part of his decision to ‘consciously allow’ the mill to go into liquidation. Hinting that his opposition must have hinged on extraneous factors, Ratan wrote that the motive behind the decision was not something he wished to ‘dwell on’. Funds were not a problem for the cash-rich Tata Sons, and it had extended such help liberally in the past.

In an interview for a book, the self-confessedly ‘sensitive’ Ratan said in response to a question regarding Empress Mills: ‘I was so disgusted by that decision that when I got my annual bonus from the Tatas, I gave it to the officers of the company … These were perfectly blameless people who now had lost their jobs through no fault of theirs because of a bad corporate decision. They had homes to run and children to educate.’

Ratan felt that the group’s social obligations should not be sacrificed at the altar of commercial expediency. He argued that though Empress Mills’ legal obligations would get extinguished, its social responsibilities towards the employees would ‘need to be acknowledged’. He made some ‘unorthodox proposal[s]’ to JRD to ameliorate the hardship of the more than 5,500 employees who stood to lose their livelihood.

His chief proposal envisaged the creation of a trust funded by the group’s cash-rich operating companies like TISCO, Tata Chemicals, Indian Hotels and Tata Electric Companies. Tata Sons and Tata Trusts should also consider contributing to it, he said. He proposed that the trust could buy the mill’s assets from the liquidator. This would insulate the workers from the hardships of the usual delay of several years it took for the sale of assets by the liquidator and the distribution of its proceeds. He surmised that it ‘would provide immediate compensation to the jobless workforce’.

In addition, he recommended that Tata Sons provide employment to the workers who would be rendered jobless. This could be achieved by, for instance, TISCO setting up a mini steel plant in Nagpur (where one of the Empress Mills facilities had existed) or relocating its old steel facility to Nagpur. Tata Exports could also establish a shoe factory or locate some of its projects in the automotive ancillary area to Nagpur. Ratan also proposed that the trust could run the mill equipment as a memory to the group founder, Jamsetji Tata, or even gift the equipment to the workers to run as a cooperative. His proposals were, in a sense, reminiscent of the welfare policies that Jamsetji used to famously advocate—providing the needy the means to earn a livelihood. But his pleas fell on deaf ears.